

Acer Aspire 2920

One look at the Aspire 2920 had us thinking cheap, tacky and plasticity. However, once you use the notebook, you realise the simple plastic beige bezel is misleading—it's clearly a cost cutting move rather than a cheap tactic to rake in bigger profit percentages on sales. The notebook has this tacky looking cover, and a cheap looking (but not so) inner bezel. What annoyed us is the large footprint (for a 12.1-inch notebook)



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courtesy a larger, rounded body. It's heavier than your average 12.1-inch too, at 2.04 kg. It's for this reason that the Aspire 2920 finds itself in this category rather than the 'ultra compact' category, which is more suited to notebooks bearing similar screen sizes. The keypad is surprisingly good, and very usable.

The configuration is fine for a regular notebook for the home or office—a 1.83 GHz Core 2 Duo, 2 GB of RAM, and a 160 GB HDD. Linux is the

Notebooks? Pocket Books? Whatever...

Fujitsu U1010



Born out of a desire to be petite, the U1010 is a tiny-but-not-pocket-compatible notebook. A laptop this is not, especially, with a screen size of 5.6 inches. It's 3.5G ready and supports HSDPA1, (acronym for High Speed Downlink Packet Access 1, a fast 3G mobile communications protocol), ready. While this may sound good to most people, it's mostly useless in India, and is strictly advertising jargon as of now. Build quality is sadly mediocre, and the swivel has a lot of play, the keypad besides being (obviously) cramped, doesn't impart too intuitive a feel. The buttons and little interface objects (shortcut keys, biometric login, WiFi switch, etc) are also weirdly placed and it'll take time to get used to using this.

With Windows Vista Home Premium, a touch screen, and a fully functional (albeit horribly cramped keypad), this tiny notebook could be easily mistaken for a large PDA. With an Intel A110, (codenamed Stealey), 800 MHz CPU, and 1 GB of RAM, this little notebook is all set to ride in your cargo pockets.

And herein lies one of its biggest advantages and drawbacks. People craving performance with mobility will look for an 11.1-inch form factor, with a usable keyboard, or at the most a compact 12.1-inch solution. But the U1010 straddles a chasm best left unabridged for the route is rife with problems. If you want something nearly pocket-able, then this may be for you. If you want a 'portable' notebook, look somewhere else. At Rs 72,000, its very niche, and if you're looking for something like this, the price shouldn't deter you.

HCL MiLeap MV02

The name notwithstanding, the MiLeap MV02 is a very large PDA or a compact notebook, depending solely on how you look at it. It's for those who want something small, with touch screen functionality, but cannot afford the price, size, or both, of a tablet PC. This is built sturdier than the Fujitsu U1010,

but we wonder about the piano black finish, which imparts the look of a designer handbag, rather than a notebook / giant PDA. The chrome buttons add some much unwanted garishness to an already non-acoustically loud device.



It's got an Intel A110 CPU running at a nominal 800 MHz, and 1 GB of RAM, coupled with 80 GB of storage. The fact that it's significantly larger than the U1010 means that its keypad is more usable too. Keypad feedback is not good however, and for the most (unless typing out a letter or something similar) you'll pretty much want to stick to the touch screen / stylus duo. For someone who's really looking for the additional functionality of a touch screen and the portability of a tiny notebook the MiLeap MV02 is a decent solution, with a killer price tag—Rs 34,990.

OS of choice, another cost cutting move. With such capers being cut, we expected the price to be really superb. At Rs 41,199, the Aspire 2920 isn't exorbitant, but it's much costlier than the Fujitsu S7211, which is a better notebook (albeit with 1 GB less memory). For this reason, as well as the quality of materials and finish on this product, we suggest you stay away from this.

HCL Z24 C2D

After the other boxy HCL notebooks we had our fingers crossed when this one's carton was popped open. To our delight, the Z24 C2D isn't as bulky as most of its siblings, although it isn't compact compared to the 14.1-inch models from other vendors. It's a 14.1-inch notebook, and the matte-finished metal lid exudes quality. At 2.31 kg, it's heavy for a 14.1-inch notebook, but the dimensions seem good. The key pad has been reworked from other HCL models, now imparting crisper feedback, and a nice springy feel from the keys. The screen is quite good. We weren't expecting such a sharp display from HCL.

A good configuration under the hood (Core 2 Duo T7250, 2 GHz), a whopping 3 GB of RAM, and a colossal 320 GB HDD make the costlier avatar of the Z24 C2D (there's a cheaper version with the same model number in our sub-40,000 category) a killer. Although a discrete graphics solution would have made this an even better notebook for multimedia aficionados, this wasn't to be. At Rs 57,740, the Z24 C2D is a powerful solution. But if you compare specifications, the Dell XPS 1530 and the Sony Vaio VGN-FZ35GN knock it into orbit in nearly every benchmark. And they're priced very close as well, which makes the Z24 C2D, a note-



HCL Z24 C2D

book which due to no fault of its own, we cannot recommend.

LG XNote E300

LG's answer for the discerning masses, the E300 is a good looking notebook with a charcoal-grey finish. It's solidly built, and the body and finish feels durable enough to last through a couple of years of abuse with relative ease. The keys are well laid out, bevelled, and exude a nice, positive, firm feedback, which makes using this a pleasure. But it's not as compact as other 13.3-inches

in the market, which is why it isn't doing a one-on-one with the XPS M1330 which features in our "ultra compact" category. At 2.04 kg, it's not the lightest of the 13.3-inch notebooks. On a different note, this notebook's left palm rest gets quite hot, presumably, because of the fact that LG uses the body of their notebooks as heatsinks. Still, the heat dissipation should be restricted to the undercarriage of the notebook, and working on this for around an hour warmed up our palms quite a bit, which is good for winter, but isn't appreciated in the month of May.



LG XNote E300

A decent configuration— T7300, 2.0 GHz, 2 GB of RAM, a Radeon Xpress 1250, and a screen size of 13.3 inches—mean the XNote is a good notebook for road warriors and desktop oriented users alike. Although the Radeon chipset won't do gaming or even serious HD playback (at least not without the inevitable skip), the E300 features an HDMI out.

At Rs 52,000, the E300 is an attractive looking solution that finds itself in the wrong category and at the wrong end of a performance war. In this category, the cheaper Dell XPS 1530 easily wins all accolades over this, while in the compact category the Dell XPS M1330 easily won. So it's caught between a rock and a potentially hard place. Which is why we aren't recommending the E300 to anyone.

BUSINESS NOTEBOOKS: Corporate Champions

Lenovo ThinkPad X300

The new ThinkPad combines the flexibility of a 15.4 inch display in a slim and lightweight shell. The lid mounted keyboard light, superb functionality, button-type joy pad and industrial grade rugged design and finish will ensure nostalgia (read IBM). Under the hood, we were surprised to find a new super power saving U7100 Core 2 Duo processor. Remarkably, this CPU is thermally efficient, which is what makes the X300 so remarkably slim and possibly lightweight (read bulky heat-sink-free). Then Lenovo has another trick—a 60 GB solid state hard drive. This feature is a standout and the titanium reinforced body in tow means that the X300 is remarkably durable too. Bonuses like power savings and performance are also goodies to look for. With the business segment as its target audience, the X300 doesn't need a graphics solution, and guess what—it doesn't have one. Multimedia aficionados and home users—don't even 'hink ThinkPad.